



◀ MUKESH KUMAR 8 years

Pararia Village, Madhepura

Rescued by Vajinathpur Police in Saharsa district with 11 others. The traffickers were taking them to Saharsa railway station from where they would have boarded a train to Punjab. Alerted by Saharsa villagers, the police caught them on January 8.

Police Case Status

Traffickers Rajdeep Yadav and Heeralal Yadav have been arrested but they are merely local conduits.

▶ AIHSAN ALAM 9 years

Dhangama Village, Purnia

Rescued with a group of 14 other child labourers at Katihar railway station on January 17. Middleman Mohd. Musabbir had given Rs 500 to Aihsan's father Alam, a casual labourer for the boy, who was to work at a bindi factory in Delhi.

Police Case Status

GRP case (03/09) lodged. Musabbir under judicial custody. Police are yet to file chargesheet.



CHILD LABOURERS AFTER THEY WERE RESCUED AT SONBARSHA IN SAHARSA

issue. "This is helping the traffickers escape punishment. We can take action only when a child is recovered from the premises of any employer and not before," he says.

As Prasad explains, sub-brokers often buy children with the promise of taking good care of them. But they simply hand over the children to agents for a price. It is these agents who finally get the children employment in hazardous industries or as bonded labourers. "I had submitted a memorandum to the Union labour minister seeking a joint operation to clamp down on this (racket). The Union Home Ministry has issued a directive to this effect to police authorities in all states," says Prasad.

Traffickers argue that they provide the children with shelter and employment. They convince the parents that by letting their children go, they are only ensuring a better quality of life for them. But Ghuran Mahto of BBA rubbishes this. He says that the children are kept in a hostile atmosphere. "We have examples of bonded children being traded the second and third time by their masters. This is clearly slave labour," says Mahto.

But clearly, there isn't enough that is being done. Authentic official figures on the number of people affected by the floods, missing children or children being trafficked remain elusive. The Bihar Welfare Department has collaborated with Unicef and other organisations to launch a joint initiative called Sambal to target trafficking and provide psychosocial support for victims but, as a Unicef official claims, it is difficult to get hold of data. Also, while the Government's initiatives may have increased awareness, the root cause for trafficking—the financial plight of the flood victims—remains to be tackled.

A critical evaluation of the state's counter-trafficking initiatives reveals lack of coordination between the police and block development authorities who should be addressing the economic welfare of victims, real and potential. Alternate employment avenues and creating a sense of security is the need of the hour. However, child rights activists feel that the global financial crisis has aggravated the situation. "While the Kosi disaster helped the traffickers to catch ready victims, the economic downturn has provided all the more reasons to look for the cheap labour," says Ganesh Reddy of NGO Citizen Foundation.

Bihar Labour and Employment Minister Awadhesh Narayan Singh says his Ministry is aware of the realities. "We are in the process of working out a complete rehabilitation package for the child workers," he promises. But the question is, when will it come about and how adequate will it be? ■